



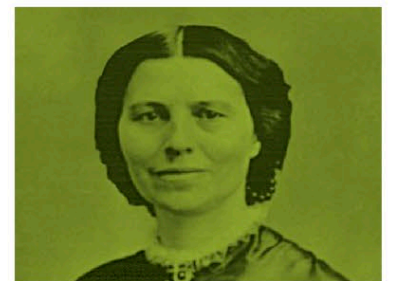
**"NO CREATURE ON
GOD'S EARTH IS LEFT
MORE ... DESOLATE
THAN THE SLAVE."**

HARRIET BEECHER STOWE, *UNCLE TOM'S CABIN*, 1852

were prostitutes. Between 400 and 750 women disguised themselves as men and enlisted to fight as soldiers; Canadian Sarah Edmonds, for example, fought for the Union Army in the Battle of Blackburn's Ford and the first Battle of Bull Run under the name Franklin Thompson. Former slave Mary Elizabeth Bowser acted as a spy for the Union, while working as a maid in the home of the Confederate president, Jefferson Davis, in Richmond, Virginia. She allegedly had a photographic memory and could recite nearly every document she saw on Davis's desk to her spymaster.

Closer to the fighting, women in the South witnessed the violence of the war first-hand. The economy in the South, which relied on close to 4 million slaves, suffered greatly, and views of the war were often linked to class or financial status. The diaries of Mary Boykin Chesnut, the wife of a southern politician, show that some wealthy women personally supported the Confederacy. However, poor white women tended to see the war as a rich man's fight; in 1863, a mob of 65 armed women looted the city of Columbus, Georgia, for food.

President Abraham Lincoln issued the Emancipation Proclamation on January 1, 1863, effectively bringing the Southern slave economy to an end. The Civil War ended with a Northern victory in 1865. Although 620,000 lives were lost in the conflict, it won the freedom of millions of enslaved women and men alike.



BIOGRAPHY

CLARA BARTON

A well-educated woman from Massachusetts, Clara Barton (1821-1912) became a nurse when civil war broke out. She was initially a teacher but volunteered as a hospital nurse to Union soldiers from 1861. Soldiers dubbed the self-taught nurse the "Angel of the Battlefield." On one occasion while nursing at the front, a bullet tore through the sleeve of her dress and killed the man she was tending. In 1881, she founded the American Red Cross.